

Ari Logan's Writing Process

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ENGL&101: English Composition I

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May 26, 2026

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I've found out a lot about how I write, and I now have the ability to put it into words what made me such a reluctant writer, how that's finally changed after exploring how people write, and what I can do differently. I'll guide you through what I've discovered. I'll start with what motivates me, why I procrastinate, and what those things mean to me. Then I'll move into what I write when I'm just getting started with a project and what has changed. The next step is to take a detour and discuss what I obsess over when I write. That leads to my distractions and how I've chosen to embrace them. And finally, I'll go over how I flesh out my ideas and arguments.

Procrastination and motivation

When I write, the first step is always to procrastinate. Wait until the last day, and don't start working until the sun starts to set. I both know and don't know why I do this. I know that I don't enjoy reading dry academic texts, so what really motivates me to start writing is to really feel that stress of an upcoming deadline. But I don't know, because I always end up enjoying what I write, and when I do start working early, it's the best feeling in the world to be done with all my responsibilities and still have most of the day left. In my writing log, you can see a consistent pattern of starting after 8 PM. (e.g., Reading Discussion: Linguistic Diversity & Code-Meshing (Writer's Choice) - 5/7/26 at 10 PM, Psyc 100: Annotated bibliography – 5/14/26 at 9 PM, Psyc 100: module 6 discussion – 5/16/26 at 8:45 PM). It leads to me being under a steady level of stress when I'm writing, which causes me to hesitate to write the next time I need to, as I would rather not be stressed like that.

Getting started

Now, once I finally get started, there's a few other obstacles. It used to be that I caused myself a lot of stress when I wrote because I didn't like my thought process, and I'd be constantly starting over without having written anything down. Usually what it means is that I have a thought, then I'd try to elaborate on it and end up not being satisfied with what I can think of. I note this phenomenon in my Self-Portrait. "And then once I've started, it's hard to think of ideas to add to, or to expand upon because every idea is unprofessional or somehow unintelligent" (para. 1). It's this unfortunate habit of treating my first draft as a final draft and worrying that people are reading what I'm writing, and they're judging me very hard. But that's changed to just start transcribing what I'm thinking. From my writing log about writing my Self-Portrait: "Every thought is a valid thought; I can get rid of what I don't like later." It's very liberating, as it takes less time (necessary when I only have 3 hours to complete an assignment), and it allows me to worry about being critical for the end. As noted by Lamott when discussing first drafts:

No one is going to see it. If the kid wants to get into really sentimental, weepy, emotional territory, you let him. Just get it all down on paper because there may be something great in those six crazy pages that you would never have gotten to by more rational, grown-up means (2005, para. 4).

When I treat my ideas with some respect, they can build each other, and I start creating structure for my text early, instead of scrambling to manufacture one at the end.

Obsession with format and rubric

Once I've got my writing going, there's something I notice I do a lot. Now it's not perfecting my thoughts before I write them down, it's obsessing over format. This is connected to what I write about related to information technology: "I should use large headers and properly

use tables of contents, appropriately use color coding, font choice, and text size for those with visual impairments” (Self-Portrait, para. 3). I’m referring to the word processing tools I use to make my work accessible and readable to a wide audience. I’m obsessed with these things.

Unfortunately for me, most of my writing recently has had to be done in APA format, which has a lot of quirks and nuances to it. I take so much time beforehand worrying if I’m using quotes correctly, if the periods and commas are in the right places, that there is never a smooth flow to my writing. I always take out a little bit of time every few minutes making dead sure I formatted that sentence correctly. As I wrote my Rhetorical Situation Assignment, I “Was paying extra close attention to my formatting, and conformity to APA. Keep trying to add thoughts to get the page requirement” (Writing log). That quote also brings up another point, which is that I have a love-hate relationship with rubrics. I use them as a crutch as to whether my writing is adequate, instead of just judging my writing on its own. There’s so much time spent looking over my work, seeing what else I can squeeze out to meet an arbitrary length requirement.

Distractions

When I’m writing, I notice I tend to get bored if I stick to something too long. So, I need to take some breaks and grab a snack. Maybe I will give into my distractions a little bit. I’ve found these are all good things for my writing. Once I get up to grab a snack, I have a little bit of time to reflect on how much I’ve got done and refuel my energy. If I get bored of my work, spending a couple minutes watching a YouTube video or continuing the show I’m watching is hugely beneficial. Boredom isn’t helpful when trying to think of ideas to add to an essay. I can work through my distractions and still get my work done. I noted in my writing log that when I was at the mall doing the module 6 discussion for my psychology class, “The group of people I was with were having a conversation, and sometimes I’d have something to say.” Even though I

got distracted by the commotion around me, I'd engage in the distraction for a moment, which would allow me to refresh my creative juices, get back some energy, and then I could go back to work. I don't think of distractions as something to eliminate; I embrace them and view them as an opportunity to reset. If I'm ever in a rut and am struggling to think of ideas, taking a short little break is the best thing to do.

Arguing my points

Now I can talk about how I write the “meat” of my work. I like to think about anything I write as if it's part of an argument. If I'm trying to convince someone of what I want from them, I need to properly give them background information for my thoughts, or else a lot of the message is lost. Here's what I say on this topic in my Self-Portrait: “If my reasoning or arguments aren't all properly portrayed, my position is much easier to take down in rebuttal” (para. 2). Just like I would in an argument, I'm going to make sure my context is accounted for when writing. For example, if I'm trying to inform someone about rhetoric, I'm going to be extra vigilant about how I introduce the different parts of the rhetorical situation; how do I define each aspect of the rhetorical situation? This way, the reader has the necessary context to understand how I apply different parts of the rhetorical situation to certain concepts.

Another thing I make sure I have when making a point is a level of critical reflection. Now that I've defined my different concepts, how are they applied in different situations, what are some examples? How would someone who isn't me view what I said? Now that's not always easy, especially if you're as critical of your ideas as I am. But as I said in my writing log about when I was responding to module 6 discussion posts: “It may seem hard to be a critical thinker, but it's not too hard after just giving it some thought and being a bit more open on what I feel I can write about.” It's necessary for me to have my ideas fleshed out, to make sure I really

thought through everything critically and that I have evidence to support those ideas. Bazerman touches on this when describing the process of “finding and gathering resources”: “You may still need to prod your memory to flesh out the details of incidents or to expand on ideas you already hold. In many cases, finding resources outside your own experiences can add strength, specificity, depth, and persuasiveness to your writing” (1997, p. 50). I really need to be able to add depth to the ideas I introduce, or else my writing would be very shallow and weak, I equivilize it to making a claim without citing a source.

All good things...

After analyzing the ways I write during these past few weeks, I’ve found the ways I got started writing were flawed and needed to be improved to allow me to be a more effective writer. And that I’m a little obsessed with format and technical consistency. I was finally able to be comfortable with distractions and learned I can embrace them. And finally, I learned what exactly I do when crafting an argument or an essay, and how it affects my writing. Learning these things has made me a more effective and efficient writer, and it has by far improved my relationship with the process.

References

Lamott, A. (2005). Shitty First Drafts. *Language Awareness: Readings for College Writers*. 9. 93-96.

Bazerman, C. (1997). *Writing Processes. Involved: Writing for College, Writing for Your Self*. Houghton Mifflin.

Self-Portrait

I've always tried to be thoughtful, tried to really think through every thought and idea I have before putting pen to paper. It's led me to be very tightly wound with my writing, as I'd rather not make a mistake and offend someone. But when I'm done, my work is nice and polished, and It's always gotten a certain level of praise. The problem though, is that's a nightmare way to write anything. I end up taking hours to get started because I know it's not going to be fun when I do start. And then once I've started, it's hard to think of ideas to add to, or to expand upon because every idea is unprofessional or somehow unintelligent. Anne Lamott describes this phenomenon as it happened to her:

Then on the following Monday I'd sit down at my desk with my notes and try to write the review. Even after I'd been doing this for years, panic would set in. I'd try to write a lead, but instead I'd write a couple of dreadful sentences, XX them out, try again, XX everything out, and then feel despair and worry settle on my chest like an x-ray apron (2005, para. 5).

Recently I've been changing that, especially to help me get through college classes where I must do much more writing than before if I want to succeed. I can't exactly give up halfway through writing my essay because I lost interest in the online argument I was participating in, and I can't have that "x-ray apron" lying on my chest either.

Which I think is an excellent way to segue into my enjoyment of debates. For a while now I've been into YouTube video essays where someone argues their opinion on a piece of media. They show other people using critical thinking and argumentative writing in a very fun and engaging way. Watching those videos has given me the start of a new writing process. I review what I'm writing about and what the requirements are, for example the proper way to

write a thank-you letter for a job interview, then I'll start transcribing what I'm thinking at that moment. It really gets all my thoughts out there, and it only requires a little bit of mental gymnastics to think that everything I wrote down is adequate. Now how does this connect back to argumentative essays? Even if the thing I'm writing about isn't some debate, I have thoughts that need to come across. Just like any essay, if my reasoning or arguments aren't all properly portrayed, my position is much easier to take down in rebuttal. Or in other words, if my thoughts aren't all there, my main thesis is moot, and the message I was trying to send with my writing is now gone.

Now what if my message isn't an argument, but information that needs to be accurately and concisely conveyed? Because of the nature of the profession I chose, Information Technology and computer systems administration, I need to write down all the work I do to be able to convey it to the people who come after me, without them ever having to meet me. That has a couple of requirements. I can't use too much jargon, or overly obscure technical language, so those who don't have the same context as I do can still understand me. I need to be clear and concise, so whoever needs to reference my documentation later doesn't have to decipher it first. And as a continuation of that idea, it needs to be accessible. I should use large headers and properly use tables of contents, appropriately use color coding, font choice, and text size for those with visual impairments. Even outside of technical reference documentation, these concepts are super important for other types of writing. For example, I don't want to write an essay without some use of headers, as I need to be able to skim at some point during essay and text analysis, especially my own writing at a later point. And of course, for the audience of my text.

What can also help readability is the language used, and this is something I've aspired to. I don't want to read a book or text that spends too much time on technical details or describing settings. There's an idea when reviewing a piece of media called pacing. How cleanly is the narrative moving along? Do they spend too much or too little time on one subject? This is an idea I incorporate into my writing. When I introduce an idea, I want to make sure that it's properly fleshed out before moving onto the next one. Usually what I find is that too little time on an idea leads to confusion about what exactly I'm talking about, and where I'm going with it. Another thing that helps pace is the language that I use: I don't want my writing to be boring or choppy because I'm not adding "cute" words or punctuation to make the different thoughts flow better. I want my writing to be fun, because well, it's more engaging to read, but it's also a better portrayal of my personality and allows me to communicate more effectively.

References

- Lamott, A. (2005). Shitty First Drafts. *Language Awareness: Readings for College Writers*. 9.
93-96.

Writing Log

Table 1

Writing Log

Date & Time Duration Location	Task	Patterns	Distractions	Snacks Breaks	Notes
5/7/26 10 PM 2 hours Home Desk	Reading Discussion: Linguistic Diversity & Code-Meshing (Writer's Choice)	I really enjoyed the actual reading part of this one. I was engaged the whole time, as the language the author used wasn't the dry standard English I was used to in academic texts.	I kept checking into YouTube, and then eventually I got too tired to continue.	N/A N/A	I came up with the first critical question really quickly, in the middle of reading.
5/1/26 8:00 PM 3 hours Home Desk	Rhetorical situation assignment	Was paying extra close attention to my formatting, and conformity to APA. Keep trying to add thoughts to get the page requirement.	The X-Files, I was bingeing that, but I was mostly focused on my essay.	N/A N/A	Got most of the way done on the first, added a few more secondary sources
5/13/25 8 AM 20 minutes The bus	Interview thank-you email	Wrote down my thoughts, then checked out the interview thank you assignment from all the way back from bit 100 to compare to see if it fit, and what else I should add.	None, sitting on the bus doesn't allow for many	None 1, to sit and ponder.	Really following <i>shitty first drafts</i> well, not worrying too much on how my first draft is looking.
5/14/26 9 PM 3 hours Home Desk	Psyc 100: Annotated bibliography	Skimmed the article I picked, look for the most important parts to put in a summary. Writing each summary took about half an hour, then once I was done with summaries for each article, I went onto the next part which was describing what the articles' conclusions were and how they compared to the other articles.	Little distractions, as I really needed to get it done, but towards the end I was anxious.	m&m chocolate chip cookie 0	Procrastination to the last minute led to a stressful, chaotic, but kinda fun experience.
5/16/26 8:45 PM 45 minutes Bellis Fair Mall	Psyc 100: module 6 discussion	Read, watched video, summarized, had a minor distraction, repeat.	The group of people I was with were having a conversation, and sometimes I'd have something to say.	Chicken burger 3	Made me confident in my ability to work through distractions
5/19/26 9 PM 1 hours In bed	Psyc 100: Module 6 discussion (responses)	Find a reply, read what other people thought to have a benchmark, got down my initial thought, was critical of the lack of critical thinking, so added a more in depth final thought	Just youtube	Sugar cookie 1, I wanted to finish watching a video I started. Was roughly halfway done.	It may seem hard to be a critical thinker, but it's not too hard after just giving it some thought and being a bit more open on what I feel I can write about.
5/23/26 8:30 PM 2 hours In bed	Psyc 100: Media examples of Personality Differences	Try and think of a clip from a show I like, preferably humorous, try and find the best version of the clip on youtube, clip wasn't good enough, repeat	I'd been working on installing an operating system a lot of the day, and it was still a minor distraction	I made a coffee almond fudge milkshake 2, one to take a break and reflect to think of a	Man it was hard to find that clip! But once I found the one I liked, the

	or Gender roles			clip I could use for the response, and the other to make that milkshake	ideas just came rolling in.
5/23/26 11 PM 1 hour In bed	Writing influences vision board	I would think about what inspired the way I read a write, they were easy to find! It was also easy to describe why they were important to my writing, my inhibitions to writing are officially gone.	The Simpsons	Candy cookie 1, to stand up and stretch my legs, get a snack.	These lower stakes, more subjective assignments are more fun to write for, because I'm not always worrying about if it's going to match the grading rubric.
5/25/26 1 AM 2 hours In bed	Self portrait (half draft)	I just wrote, it was great. Every thought is a valid thought; I can get rid of what I don't like later.	Youtube	None 0, I didn't get up once.	The transformation is finally complete, my obsession over a perfect first draft is over. Though this may be a problem later if I treat my first draft as a final draft.

